On your first day inside, you witness a fight between two groups of inmates. The staff breaks up the fight with excessive violence. People are ushered to the Central Tihar Jail Hospital. There is an atmosphere of increased distrust and hostility. You don't who to speak to or how. You are unsure as to how to act—cool nonchalance or friendly warmth? You find a comfortable corner in the barracks hall and settle down for the night. Tomorrow, you will somehow have to figure out everything.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

PRE-BAIL

There is something wrong with the food. It feels stale and flavourless. The *dal* is too watery and the *chapati* is too tough. As a result you have been feeling weak and unwell lately— fever, stomach cramps, constipation, and even tooth ache. You have no energy to get a job, or even to speak to anyone, and have been missing *mulaqats* as a result. When you get the chance to call your family, they express their worry over your deteriorating health.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

PRE-BAIL

The lawyer assigned to your case is extremely callous. During the first meeting itself, they come off as arrogant and impatient, cutting you off often. They attempt to explain the charges levelled against you, but give up when they realise that you are unable to follow along. At the end, they tell you that they'll be able to secure your bail, but you do not feel anything but belittled and frustrated.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

PRE-BAIL

Finally you are able to go for the *mulaqat*. You wake up early and get dressed because you want to look presentable for the occasion. However, you are only able to see your sister. She informs you that your parents couldn't bear to come and see you. This revelation sets the tone for the rest of the meeting. When she leaves, she confesses that she is not sure whether she'd be able to come again.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

PRE-BAIL

On the day of your hearing, you wait for your case to be called. Your lawyer is confident it will work out, but you are feeling really anxious. You are unable to find your parents in the room, but at least your sister is present. You try to keep cognizance of the proceedings, but are unable to focus on anything except your own breathing. Thankfully by the end, the judge announces that bail will be granted on the date of the next hearing.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

PRE-BAIL

When the date of the next hearing arrives, the bail is granted at once. You breathe a sigh of relief. When you step into the jail again, you know it is for the last time. The few inmates you have spoken to ask you for a treat. They also ask you to recount the proceedings of the hearing. You find that you cannot recall a single thing.

BAIL

BAIL

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

POST-BAIL

Your fellow inmates have informed you that once the Bail Order arrives, a series of steps need to be followed to acquire the Release Order, which is what will finally allow you to return home. Your Bail Order arrives the night before Gandhi Jayanti, and you only hear of it after the long weekend ends. There is endless red-tape to be parsed, and you are already exhausted.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

POST-BAIL

You have been told to carefully check the information within the Bail Order. Other inmates have made you aware of the fact that any error within the Bail Order will mean that your release will be pushed back by over a week. You anxiously scan the document and find that there is a *dhaara* missing. It will need to be sent back. You plan a visit to the DSLSA lawyer for the same. This is going to take a lot of time now.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

POST-BAIL

There surety amount is unfortunately quite high. You phone your sister to inform her of the same. The RC of the car will need to be deposited to the court and processed for the Release Order to arrive. Your sister promises to go as soon as she can, but you feel guilty for all the financial and mental pressure you are putting your family under.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

POST-BAIL

Your sister calls you to let you know that the RC has been deposited. You wait keenly on the Release Order. It is now a matter of two or three days. Every day feels unbearably long.

KHEL RIHAAI KA

-

POST-BAIL


RIHAAI


RIHAAI